openRxiv Labs

Labs Launch post

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Over the last thirteen years, bioRxiv and medRxiv have become foundational infrastructure for rapid research sharing in biology and medicine by providing steady, trustworthy, researcher-driven platforms for disseminating preprints. A core part of our mission at openRxiv is continuing to responsibly steward these platforms to maintain and build on the trusted foundation we've established. At the same time, we recognize that the research ecosystem is evolving rapidly, driven by changes in global economics, policy, and technology. We believe it is critical that we take a leadership role in helping our community adapt to these changes without disrupting the core of what makes openRxiv a leader in biomedical preprinting.

Today, we're thrilled to announce the launch of openRxiv Labs, a space for experimenting with new ideas and opportunities that push the boundaries of research communication. At openRxiv Labs, we will work with innovative partners to build new experiences on top of openRxiv's unique corpus of preprints and related research outputs that explore what the future of open scientific communication could look like.

The first experiment, a test of a new, interactive preprint reading experience in partnership with Curvenote, will launch in early June. We're excited to share more details about this experiment next week. To receive updates, sign up to receive the openRxiv newsletter.

To ensure that openRxiv Labs is as impactful as possible, we're taking a unique approach to building it. Instead of running a large number of smaller tests at one time, we will be focusing on hosting a limited number of bold, large-scale experiments that have a chance to dramatically improve the status quo of preprinting. Rather than running everything in-house, we'll be collaborating with partners who bring different perspectives and can draw on our team's wealth of experience and expertise. Because of the scale of these projects, we will be conducting them like true experiments, with pre-defined hypotheses, goals, success metrics, and durations. We will openly publish the results of our experiments on the openRxiv Labs blog — even if they fail, which we expect many will.

In 2026, we plan to run three experiments, including the first one with Curvenote, that explore key areas of opportunity we've identified in conjunction with our community and stakeholders: the preprint reading experience, enabling curation, and responsible and impactful use of artificial intelligence. You can learn more about these opportunity areas on the openRxiv Labs website.

We believe the ongoing rapid changes to the research publishing ecosystem, combined with openRxiv's unique corpus and trusted relationships with authors, readers, and institutions, presents a unique opportunity to catalyze the next generation of open science tools and practices. We look forward to meeting this opportunity with openRxiv Labs by building a coalition of researchers, innovative builders, advocates, funders, and institutions ready to join us in bold experimentation with the future of preprinting. If you're interested in participating, please visit the openRxiv Labs website or reach out to us at hello@openrxivlabs.org.

Published May 28, 2026

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